

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1998-03-04

1 dear bahá'í friends,
2 about your review of music and special materials. . . . we are to convey the
3 following reply.

**The memorandum on bahá'í publishing dated riḡván 1971, which the
house of justice sent to National Spiritual Assemblies, states that**

4 At this early stage of the cause all works by bahá'ís which deal with the
5 faith, whether in the form of books, pamphlets, translations, poems,
6 songs, radio and television scripts, films, recordings, etc. must be ap-

proved before submission for publication, whether to a bahá'í or non-

7 bahá'í publisher. in the case of material for purely local consumption

the competent authority is the local Spiritual Assembly, otherwise

the National Spiritual Assembly (through its reviewing committee)

is the approving authority.259-1

8 The obligation, as indicated in this statement, of Spiritual Assemblies
9 to ensure the appropriateness of books, music and other items intended for
10 dissemination in the interests of the faith remains unchanged for the time

11 259-1. muh, no. 94.258.7

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260 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

261 610being; but it will have to be carried out with flexibility in the light of chang-

262 ing circumstances. The house of justice recognizes that the volume and

263 variety of materials being created have greatly increased with the growth in size of
the bahá'í community and the rapid advance and ease of use of

264 communication and other technologies.

265 Applying review standards to manuscripts is, of course, relatively straight-

266 forward, whereas doing so with respect to different types of music and the wide
range of items categorized as "special materials" poses a particular chal-lenge to those
responsible for reviewing them. Since the form, expression and effect of music are, to a great
extent, determined by the cultural norms

267 of a society, the reviewing agency called upon to decide on the acceptability

268 of proposed musical items must be sensitive and flexible in its judgment. The value of
having National and local Spiritual Assemblies exercise such

269 judgment is obvious in the fact that what may well be accepted as appropri-ate in one
place may have the opposite effect in another. moreover, an aspect

270 of the flexibility called for is recognizing that all acceptable musical items are not
suitable for all bahá'í occasions. for example, a distinction must be

271 made between the music employed for devotional services and that used for other
occasions in the b ahá'í community.

272 Special materials, such as those listed in your letter (i.e. art prints, tee-

273 shirts, cards, automobile bumper stickers, book marks, calendars, jewelry,

274 and art work that includes the greatest Name and the ringstone symbol),

275 are so numerous, so varied and, in many instances, so ephemeral, that it

276 would be impossible for any national agency to cope with the demands for

277 review of them all. it is necessary therefore that your National Assembly de-

278 termine what types of items must be reviewed and by what standard. As for

279 the others, you will have to allow some latitude in their production, while continuing
to educate the friends as to the principles that should guide their

280 creation of such items.

The house of justice applauds your intention to mount an effort to

281 educate the friends concerning the standards to be upheld in creating, pub-

282 lishing and distributing all kinds of materials involving the faith and its

283 symbols. in time, as the friends themselves increasingly exercise wise dis-

284 crimination in choosing between appropriate and inappropriate items in circulation,
the exertions of the institutions in promoting these standards

285 will bring about the desired results.

286 with loving b ahá'í greetings,

for Department of tHe secretariat259.4

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**Passing of Hugh E. Chance, Former Member of the
Universal House of Justice**

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]